

The Cycle Fitness Guide

Train smarter by working with your hormones.

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Stop Training Against Your Hormones

Most fitness programmes ignore one fundamental biological reality: women are not small men. Your hormones change profoundly across your cycle, dramatically affecting your strength, endurance, recovery capacity, injury risk, and motivation. Training the same way every week — regardless of where you are in your cycle — leads to suboptimal performance, increased injury risk, and hormonal disruption. Cycle syncing your exercise changes everything.

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Studies show women who align training intensity with their cycle phases see 20–30% greater strength gains in the follicular phase and significantly lower injury rates overall, compared to women training on a fixed weekly programme.

WHAT'S INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- The hormonal basis of female athletic performance — what the science actually says
- Phase-by-phase exercise protocols for strength, cardio, and recovery
- Full 28-day workout schedule aligned to the four cycle phases
- The injury-risk window: when to back off and why it matters
- Nutrition strategies for fuelling each phase's training demands
- How hormonal contraceptives affect athletic performance

KEY TAKEAWAY

You will not lose fitness by reducing intensity in the luteal phase. You will gain it — because recovery is where adaptation happens, and your hormones are signalling your body to recover during this phase.

How Your Hormones Affect Performance

Your cycle creates four distinct physiological environments that directly affect your capacity to exercise, recover, and adapt. Understanding this gives you a strategic advantage — you can time your peak-performance training to when your biology is most supportive, and protect your recovery windows.

ESTROGEN & PERFORMANCE

Estrogen increases collagen synthesis (joint stability), improves glucose utilisation, supports muscle protein synthesis, and enhances mood and motivation for exercise. Peak estrogen in the late follicular and ovulatory phases creates your biological performance window — the time when you are strongest, fastest, and most injury-resistant.

PROGESTERONE & RECOVERY

Progesterone has a catabolic effect — it increases muscle protein breakdown and raises core body temperature by 0.3–0.5°C. It also increases perceived effort during exercise (the same pace feels harder). This is not weakness; it is your body signalling a recovery need. Honouring it accelerates long-term athletic development.

RELAXIN & INJURY RISK

Relaxin — a hormone that peaks around ovulation — increases ligament laxity to support potential implantation. This temporarily increases ACL and other ligament injury risk by 2–8× around ovulation. Avoid maximum-load lifts and high-impact cutting movements in the 2–3 days around ovulation.

CORTISOL & TRAINING LOAD

Overtraining without adequate cycle-phase-appropriate recovery significantly elevates cortisol, suppresses ovulation, and drives the relative energy deficiency syndrome (RED-S). Women require more recovery days per cycle than training programmes designed for men typically provide.

Rest & Restore Phase

This is the phase most women feel least like exercising — and there is good reason for that. Estrogen and progesterone are at their lowest. Iron is being lost through bleeding. Prostaglandins are creating inflammation and cramping. Light movement is beneficial; high-intensity training is counterproductive.

MENSTRUAL PHASE · DAYS 1–5

Restorative Yoga Flow

□ 30–45 min

↑ Low

Focus on hip-opening poses and gentle spinal movement. Releases prostaglandin tension in the pelvic floor and lower back.

- **Reclined butterfly pose** Hold 3–5 min
- **Supported child's pose** Hold 3–5 min
- **Legs up the wall** Hold 5–10 min
- **Gentle cat-cow flow** 2 min continuous
- **Supine twist** Hold 2 min each side

OPTIONAL · HIGH ENERGY DAYS

Easy Walk or Swim

□ 20–40 min

↑ Low

If energy allows on days 3–5, gentle cardiovascular movement increases endorphins and reduces cramp intensity.

- **Walking at conversational pace** 20–30 min
- **Swimming easy laps** 20–30 min
- **Gentle cycling (flat terrain)** 20 min

Build & Progress Phase

The follicular phase is your biological spring. Rising estrogen improves strength and muscle protein synthesis, increases pain tolerance, and elevates motivation. This is the optimal time to push new personal records, increase training volume, and attempt skill-based movements that require coordination and focus.

FOLLICULAR PHASE · STRENGTH

Heavy Compound Lifts

□ 50–60 min

↑ High

Focus on progressive overload with compound movements. This is the phase to attempt new PRs. Strength adaptations are optimal now.

- **Barbell squat** 4×5 — heavy load, 3 min rest
- **Romanian deadlift** 3×6–8 — full hip hinge
- **Bench press or push variation** 4×6 — progress from last cycle
- **Barbell row** 3×8 — controlled eccentric
- **Overhead press** 3×6 — challenging weight

FOLLICULAR PHASE · CARDIO

High-Intensity Intervals

□ 30–40 min

↑ High

HIIT training has the greatest hormonal benefit in the follicular phase. Push hard — your body is primed to recover quickly.

- **Dynamic warm-up** 10 min
- **Sprint intervals 30 sec on / 90 sec off** 6–8 rounds
- **Box jumps or explosive movement** 3×8
- **Cool-down walk** 5 min

Peak Performance Phase (with Caution)

Energy and confidence peak at ovulation — but so does relaxin-related injury risk. This is excellent for cardio and skill-based training, but avoid maximum single-rep lifts and high-impact directional changes around peak ovulation.

OVULATORY PHASE · RECOMMENDED

Moderate Strength + Cardio

□ 45–55 min

↑ Medium-High

Capitalise on high energy without the maximum-load injury risk. This is ideal for endurance challenges and social fitness activities.

- **Moderate weight squats** 3×10–12 — no max effort
- **Tempo runs or cycling** 30–40 min at 70–80% effort
- **Dance class or team sport** High energy, lower ACL risk than cutting
- **Swimming intervals** 8×50m at 85% effort

LUTEAL PHASE TRAINING · DAYS 17–28

Sustain & Recover Phase

Progesterone raises perceived effort and core temperature. Recovery takes longer. Honouring this phase does not mean stopping exercise — it means training smartly. Moderate strength work, steady-state cardio, and yoga are ideal.

LUTEAL PHASE · STRENGTH

Moderate Strength + Mobility

□ 45 min

↑ Medium

Maintain strength without trying to progress. Focus on form and mind-muscle connection rather than adding load.

- **Goblet squats** 3×12 — moderate weight
- **Hip thrusts or glute bridges** 3×15 — glute activation focus
- **Dumbbell rows** 3×12 — each side
- **Lateral band walks** 2×20 each direction
- **Stretching and mobility** 10 min post-workout

Your Full Month of Training

This schedule assumes a typical 28-day cycle. Adjust the phase lengths based on your own cycle tracking. The principle: high intensity in follicular, moderate at ovulation, lower in luteal, rest and restore in menstrual.

Day 1	REST <i>Menstrual day 1 — rest or gentle walk only</i>
Day 2	RESTORATIVE YOGA <i>Hip-opening yoga flow, 30–45 min</i>
Day 3	REST <i>Continue rest if flow is heavy</i>
Day 4	GENTLE WALK <i>20–30 min easy walking if energy allows</i>
Day 5	LIGHT YOGA <i>Transition to slightly more active yoga</i>
Day 6	STRENGTH A <i>Lower body focus: squats, deadlifts — start building</i>
Day 7	HIIT CARDIO <i>20–30 min interval session</i>
Day 8	REST <i>Active recovery: walk or light stretching</i>
Day 9	STRENGTH B <i>Upper body: press, row, pull variations</i>
Day 10	MODERATE CARDIO <i>35–40 min steady-state or tempo run</i>
Day 11	STRENGTH A <i>Lower body — increase load from Day 6</i>
Day 12	HIIT CARDIO <i>Push intensity — follicular peak</i>
Day 13	REST <i>Prepare for ovulatory peak performance</i>
Day 14	PEAK PERFORMANCE <i>Best workout of cycle — attempt a challenge</i>
Day 15	MODERATE CARDIO <i>45 min steady state: run, cycle, swim</i>
Day 16	STRENGTH (moderate) <i>No max lifts — focus form and volume</i>

Training Schedule Continued — Days 17–28

Day 17	STRENGTH (moderate) <i>Begin reducing load; focus on technique</i>
Day 18	YOGA / PILATES <i>Core stability and hip mobility focus</i>
Day 19	EASY WALK <i>30–40 min low-impact movement</i>
Day 20	STRENGTH (light) <i>Bodyweight or light resistance — feel it out</i>
Day 21	SWIMMING or CYCLING <i>Low-impact cardio, 30–40 min</i>
Day 22	REST <i>Active recovery day</i>
Day 23	MODERATE STRENGTH <i>Maintain but don't push</i>
Day 24	YOGA FLOW <i>Focus on breathwork during practice</i>
Day 25	EASY WALK <i>Nature walk if possible — reduces cortisol</i>
Day 26	REST or STRETCH <i>Prepare body for upcoming menstrual phase</i>
Day 27	RESTORATIVE YOGA <i>Begin wind-down protocol</i>
Day 28	REST <i>Gentle movement only; nourish and rest</i>

2–8×

Higher ACL risk at ovulation

+30%

Strength gains: follicular focus

Day 7

Earliest high-intensity training

10°C

Ideal sleep temperature

Phase-Specific Sports Nutrition

Your nutritional needs for exercise change with your hormones. Underfuelling in the luteal phase — when your body needs more — is one of the most common causes of hormonal disruption in active women. Here is how to fuel each phase.

MENSTRUAL PHASE

Pre-workout: warm oatmeal + banana. Post-workout: iron-rich protein (beef, lentils). Focus: replenish iron, reduce inflammation with omega-3s. Avoid: cold foods and drinks which can worsen cramping.

FOLLICULAR PHASE

Pre-workout: fast carbs + protein 60–90 min before. Post-workout: 30g protein within 30 minutes for maximum muscle protein synthesis. Focus: higher carb intake is well-tolerated now. Leverage the insulin sensitivity window.

OVULATORY PHASE

Pre-workout: fruit + light protein. Post-workout: anti-inflammatory meal with omega-3s. Focus: antioxidant-rich foods to combat the oxidative stress of high-output training. Hydrate well — progesterone's onset increases fluid loss.

LUTEAL PHASE

Increase daily calories by 150–300 kcal — your body genuinely needs more. Complex carbs before training support serotonin and performance. Post-workout: prioritise recovery nutrition with protein + carbs + anti-inflammatory foods. Do not restrict.

The Cycle Training Cheat Sheet

MENSTRUAL

Days 1–5

LOW

Yoga, walking

Rest is training. Honour the bleed.

FOLLICULAR

Days 6–13

HIGH

Strength PRs, HIIT

Your peak adaptation window. Push now.

OVULATORY

Days 14–16

MEDIUM-HIGH

Endurance, skill

High energy — avoid max-load lifting (relaxin).

LUTEAL

Days 17–28

MEDIUM-LOW

Moderate strength, yoga

Maintain, recover, nourish. Don't restrict calories.

❏ RED FLAGS · STOP TRAINING IF YOU EXPERIENCE

- Persistent cycle irregularity or loss of period (oligomenorrhea / amenorrhea)
- Bone stress injuries — sign of energy deficiency and estrogen deficit
- Extreme fatigue that doesn't improve with rest between cycles
- Loss of ovulation signs — indicates the training load is suppressing the HPO axis

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The Flora Collection

01 · The 28-Day Hormone Reset

02 · The Cycle Syncing Meal Bible

03 · The Hormone Type Guide

04 · The Symptom Decoder

05 · The PMS Elimination Guide

06 · The Cortisol Reset

07 · The Cycle Fitness Guide

08 · The 90-Day Rebalancing Roadmap

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